

A Model of Emotional Intelligence, Subjective Happiness, and Job Performance

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Executive Summary

The emotional intelligence construct (EI) and subjective happiness (SH) have been studied separately by researchers to better understand their impacts on job satisfaction, organizational citizenship behavior, turnover intention, and commitment of employees in organizations. The present study investigates the relationships of emotional intelligence to subjective happiness and job performance. Questionnaire data on EI and SH were collected from a collegiate sample ($N = 611$) of dyads of students at a state university in the United States, who were employed at various local organizations and on job performance data were collected from respondents' respective supervisors. Data from each respondent on all three measures were matched. The data on EI were collected at the beginning of a semester, but the data on SH and JP were collected at the end of a semester. Data analysis shows that EI is positively associated SH which, in turn, is positively associated with JP.

Also the existing literature shows that EI is associated with a number of positive outcomes. These findings have significant implications for organizations. At the micro-level,

organization leaders should try to improve the EI competencies of the employees, particularly managers, through appropriate training. Organizations can also recruit employees who are high on EI. At the macro-level, organizations should try to create a culture of learning that fosters EI competences of organizational members. Additionally, organizations should create somewhat flat and flexible organization structure that will foster the use of EI competencies for productive purposes.

Keywords: intelligence, emotional intelligence, non-cognitive intelligence, job performance

The concepts of emotional intelligence (EI) and subjective happiness (SH) has attracted the attention of scholars and management practitioners around the world, in particular, their impacts on job performance (JP), satisfaction, organizational citizenship behavior, and commitment of employees in organizations. Educators, business executives, psychologists, and human resource professionals are now interested in the phenomena of EI and SH to find how productivity can be enhanced. Thus, a literature search on “emotional intelligence and subjective happiness” in PsycInfo resulted in 60 hits, which indicates that there is interest among scholars in this area of research and learning.

Common sense dictates that people need more than an intelligent quotient (IQ) to perform well in school and the workplace. Generally, social scientists and management practitioners associate intelligence construct with cognitive or academic intelligence (IQ) and assume that employees with high cognitive intelligence perform better in their organizations. Unfortunately, there is a marginal correlation between IQ and job performance (cf. Judge, Colbert, & Ilies, 2004; Rosete & Ciarrochi, 2005).

Is it possible that there are non-cognitive forms of intelligence that may be associated with employees' SH and JP? Yes, scholars have been discussing other dimensions of intelligence: emotional intelligence (Goleman, 1996; Mayer, Salovey, & Caruso, 2008), social intelligence (Rahim, 2014; Sternberg, 2002), and cultural intelligence (van Dyne, Ang, & Koh, 2009) that may be associated with JP. EI is

intrapersonal intelligence that is differentiated from interpersonal intelligence, such as social and cultural intelligence, but there are some overlaps among these constructs. EI is a relatively new construct and there are several shortcomings in the EI literature.

Shortcomings of the Existing Studies on EI and SH

1. Many studies in the EI literature have used self-report measures of both EI and criterion measures, such as job satisfaction (e.g., Walter, Cole, & Humphrey, 2011; Zacher, McKenna, & Rooney, 2013). This resulted in common method bias that is variance attributable to the measurement method rather than to the constructs the measures represent (e.g., Lassk & Shepherd, 2013). Common method variance is also present in the SH studies. It is possible that there were studies on self-reported measures of EI and an independent measure of job performance, but their non-significant relationships were not reported. Recently there were three meta-analytic studies on EI, but the criterion variables did not include an independent measure, such as job performance (Miao, Humphrey, & Qian, 2017a, 2017b, 2017c).

2. The second issue is concerned with adding all the responses to items of an EI instrument and creating a single index of EI (e.g., Kobe, Reiter-Palmon, & Rickers, 2001). This type of analysis ignores the factorial independence of the EI components that are interlinked and how they influence criterion measures.

3. The third issue was associated with the existing studies is that associations between variables were reported as correlations. Traditional statistical analysis like regression analysis, which reduces correlations among the exogenous variables (i.e., the EI components) ignore the meaningful links among the EI components. No attempt was made to develop and test causal models with structural equations. These models can explain how the EI components are linked with each other and how they influence the endogenous variables like SH and job performance and satisfaction. To the best of our knowledge, there were no empirical studies investigating the relationships of the various components of EI to the independent measures of SH and JP with structural equations models; however, there is much anecdotal evidence of these relationships.

In this present study, we attempt to bridge these gaps and make a value-added contribution to the literature. It is designed to develop a process model of EI, SH, and JP and test it with structural equations. To overcome the problem of common method variance, data on EI were collected from students at the beginning of a semester, data on SH were collected at the middle of the semester, and the data on JP were collected from the students' respective supervisors at the end of the semester.

Emotional Intelligence Construct

Some employers and managers still believe that their own and employees' emotions should be left out of the organizations. Now there is greater awareness that emotions – feelings, impulse, excitement, joy, frustration, anxiety, sadness – “march with us right into the office or onto the job site” (Nelton, 1996, p. 2) and if emotions are managed wisely, can improve individual, group, and organizational effectiveness. Emotions used wisely to attain desirable goals may be called emotional intelligence.

EI was first formally defined by Salovey and Mayer (1990) as “the ability to monitor one's own and other's feelings and emotions, to discriminate among them and to use this information to guide one's thinking and actions” (p. 189). This definition is still appropriate today. Goleman (1998) offers a complimentary definition which focuses on the abilities relating to organizing one's and others' feelings, motivating oneself, and managing one's emotions and in relationships. Davies, Stankov, and Roberts (1998) identify the following four EI dimensions, quite similar to Mayer and Salovey: appraisal and expression of emotion in oneself, appraisal and recognition of emotion in others, regulation of emotion in oneself and others, and using emotion to facilitate performance. The different conceptualizations of EI presented above complement rather than contradict one another. For the purpose of the present study, EI is formally defined as one's ability to utilize emotions to interact effectively with the internal and external environments to be successful in life or in organizations. Four components of EI that allow an individual to be successful are: (1) self-awareness, (2) awareness of others' emotions, (3) regulating emotions in self and others, and (4) using emotions for productive purposes. These components of EI are discussed in the context of the relationship between managers and

subordinates in organizations. Scholars assume that individuals who attend to emotion in self and in others and that those who manage their and others' emotion appropriately have a higher probability of performing better at work (Davis et al., 1998; Law, Wong, & Song, 2004; Rahim et al., 2002).

Components of EI

Self-awareness. For a long time, this concept has been the subject-matter for discussion in a wide variety of academic disciplines and now it is the most important component of EI. Nothing is going to happen without self-awareness. Several scholars have concluded that leaders with high self-awareness are likely to be perceived as effective leaders (e.g., Butler, Kwantes, & Boglarsky, 2014; Duval & Wickland, 1972; Silvia & Duval, 2001).

For the purpose of the present study, self-awareness refers to the ability to perceive and understand one's own emotions as well as to express emotions naturally (Mayer, Salovey, & Caruso, 2008). Individuals with this ability are aware of which emotions, feelings, moods, and impulses they are experiencing and why. Put it in another way, individuals with this ability have better grasp of their own strengths, weaknesses, and motivation and can build on the strengths and improve on weaknesses. This component of EI not only includes the extent to which individuals are sensitive to how they are perceived by others, but also their awareness of the effects of their feelings on others. Self-aware individuals are better at incorporating information from others into their self-appraisals, and ultimately, into their behavior (Moshavi, Brown, & Dodd, 2003, p. 407). Further, "one's ability to perceive emotions within oneself accurately is related to the ability to assess them in others" (Barbutto & Burbuch, 2006, p. 55).

Effective managers are able to recognize their own feelings and able to handle those feelings without being overwhelmed by them. Such ability allows an individual to use feelings to make decisions with confidence. Managers have to work with people, thus it is important that they identify and understand their own feelings, for example feeling tired, sad, happy, nervous, irritated, and anxious while communicating with others. Argyris and Schon (1978) discuss how people are often unaware of the gap that exists between theories they espouse and their theory in use. They suggest continuous learning to

close the gap between these theories. This should improve self-awareness.

Awareness of Others' Emotions. Understanding the emotions of others refers to one's ability to perceive and understand what others are feeling. Those who understand their own emotions are likely to understand the emotions of others. The ability to identify how others feel in an organization enables managers to make appropriate decisions involving employees (Law, Wong, & Song, 2004). Backett, Rivers, and Salovey's (2011) literature review suggests that EI helps individuals to increase their quality of relationships and they are viewed as interpersonally sensitive. This ability enhances effectiveness of group leadership, conflict management, negotiations, individual and group interactions, customer service, and making deals.

Individuals with this ability are sensitive to the emotions of others and are also able to predict others' emotional responses. By understanding the emotions of subordinates, managers can persuade them to work towards the attainment of organization's goals, promote harmony, motivate others to learn, create a collaborative culture, and encourage team-building.

As discussed before, people who have self-awareness are also likely to be aware of others' emotions. Davis, Stankov, and Roberts (1998) concluded that understanding of one's own and the feelings of others may be inseparable. "Thus, empathy may involve both one's ability to identify with the feelings of others and general access to one's own feelings state" (p. 991). It appears that this is consistent with the theory of mind (ToM) (Mitchell, 1997). The ToM is associated with one's ability to attribute mental states to self and others and to use these attributions to understand, predict, and explain one's own and other's behaviors (see Bulgarelli, Testa, & Molina, 2015).

Emotional Regulation in Self and Others. This component refers to the ability to keep one's own emotions and impulses in check, to remain calm in potentially volatile situations, and to maintain composure irrespective of one's emotions (Rahim et al., 2002). Self-regulation is "often defined as an ability to control attention and emotions, to plan, and to inhibit or initiate behaviors that are conducive to achieving one's goals" (Dich, Doan, & Evans, 2015, p. 369; see also Gross, 2007). Individuals with this ability are less likely to lose their temper and can return to a normal psychological state after an

emotional encounter. Emotional regulation has been linked to mental and physical health (Gross & Munoz, 1995) and job performance (Diefendorff, Hall, Lord, & Streat, 2000).

Individuals with this ability are not only able to regulate their own emotions, but also are able to regulate emotions in others. Regulation of emotions includes one's ability to lessen negative emotions of others, i.e. calm the distressing emotions of others so that common goals can be attained (Salovey & Mayer, 1990). Individuals high on this ability are able to motivate themselves and others and do not need instant gratification for their achievements. They also have the ability to handle interpersonal conflict with superiors, subordinates, colleagues, and customers functionally, i.e. they generally try to use collaborative win-win, as opposed to bargaining win-lose solutions, to maximize joint gains of self and others.

Using Emotions for Productive Purposes. This component of EI refers to one's ability to remain focused on utilizing emotions for effective outcomes in their lives or organizations. Individuals with this ability direct their emotions towards productive activities, continuously motivate themselves, and strive to do better. These individuals are likely to impact on their own and others' job performance. They are not only able to motivate themselves to do a better job but also serve as role models for others to follow with the intent of improving performance (Davies et al., 1998).

The three components of SI – emotional awareness of self as well as others and emotional regulation of self and others – discussed before are the antecedent conditions to using emotions for productive purposes. It all starts with the emotional awareness of self and others which are positively linked to emotional regulation of self and others. This, in turn, influences using emotions for productive purposes. This component is not effective unless the previous three components are present. It is expected that this component will positively influence employees' subjective happiness and job performance.

Effective leaders and managers with this ability are likely to positively impact on their own and their subordinates' subjective happiness and job performance and satisfaction. They are not only able to motivate themselves to do a better job, but also serve as role models for others to follow with the intent of improving organizational

effectiveness and efficiency. These individuals can remain focused on goals despite setbacks.

Subjective Happiness

Subjective happiness, that evolved from positive psychology movement, is associated with one's feelings rather than an objective evaluation of the level of his/or global happiness (Lyubomirsky & Lepper, 1999). Existing research shows that subjective happiness is associated with many positive outcomes (positive emotions, satisfying relationships, self-esteem, and quality of relationships) (e.g., Furnham & Patrides, 2003).

Past studies reported positive relationship between emotional intelligence and subjective happiness (e.g., Nozaki & Koyasu, 2016; Sgczygel & Mikolajczak, 2017). There is a great deal of interest among scholars to investigate the relationship between employee well-being and productivity. A study by Zelenski, Murphy, and Jenkins (2008) suggests that "happiness may indeed foster productivity" (p. 535). A similar conclusion was reached by another study that investigated the link between subjective well-being not only at individual and firm levels, but also at the country level (DiMaria, Peroni, & Sarracino, 2019). Taking lead from these studies we decided to investigate the relationship between employee subjective happiness and job performance.

The present study uses an ability-based measure of EI, and SH and JP. The study model, as shown in Figure 1 (see Appendix), the four components of EI are logically interconnected. It all starts with self-awareness as well as awareness of others' emotions. These two cannot be separated from each other. Individuals who are high in self-awareness and awareness of others' emotions are able to regulate emotions in self and others. Those who are able to regulate their own and others' emotions can remain focused on using emotions for productive purposes. This facilitates job performance. To the best of our knowledge, this sort of process model was not developed and tested before. Based on this and previous discussion, the following hypotheses are formulated:

- Hypothesis 1:* Self-awareness mediates the relationship between awareness of others' emotions and regulation of emotions in self and others.
- Hypothesis 2:* Regulation of emotions in self and others mediates the relationship between self-awareness and using emotions for productive purposes.
- Hypothesis 3:* Regulation of emotions in self and others mediate the relationship between awareness of others' emotions and using emotions for productive purposes.
- Hypothesis 4:* Using emotions for productive purposes mediates the relationship between regulating emotions in self and others and job performance.

Method

Samples

Sample. Data for this sample came from 611 dyads consisting of employed management students in an American university and their respective supervisors. Average age and job experience of the respondents were 22.30 ($SD = 4.19$) and 3.21 ($SD = 4.26$), respectively. About 35.5% of the respondents were female.

Measurement

Emotional Intelligence. This was measured with the 28 items (7 items for each of the four components) of the EQ Index (EQI) developed by Rahim (2002) and revised and improved for the present study. The EQI was designed on the basis of repeated feedback from respondents and faculty and an iterative process of exploratory and confirmatory factor analyses of various sets of items in multiple samples. Considerable attention was devoted to the study of published instruments on EQ. The final revision of the instrument was made on the basis of a confirmatory factor analysis of the observed variables (items).

The instrument uses a 5-point Likert scale (5 = Strongly Agree . . . 1 = Strongly Disagree) for ranking each of the items and a higher score indicates a greater EI component of an employee. The subscales

were created by averaging responses to their respective items. Sample items are: “I am aware of my impulses” (self-awareness); “I have good sense of the emotions of others” (awareness of others’ emotions); “I am able to calm distressing emotions of others” (regulation of others’ emotions); “I am able to maintain my composure irrespective of my emotions” (self-regulation); and “Sometimes I hesitate to make sacrifices to achieve organizational goals” (using emotions for productive purposes, *reverse coded*). Rahim (2002) provided evidence of internal consistency and indicator reliabilities and convergent and discriminant validities of the instrument and that it was free from social desirability response bias. The present study also provides evidence of psychometric properties of the revised instrument. The instrument was completed by students at the beginning of a semester (Time 1).

Subjective Happiness. This was measured with Lyubomirsky and Lepper’s (1999) 5-item Subjective Happiness scale (SHS). The items are rated on a 7-point Likert scale. A sample item is as follows:

In general, I consider myself:

Not a very happy person 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 A very happy person

The scale was created by averaging the responses to the items. A higher score represents greater subjective happiness. The designers of the instrument provided evidence of acceptable psychometric properties of the instrument. The instrument was completed by students during the middle of a semester (Time 2)

Job Performance. This was measured with the 8 items of job performance subscale adopted from the Minnesota Satisfactoriness Scale (MSS) (Gibson, Weiss, Dawis, & Lofquist, 1970). This subscale measures a subordinate’s promotability, quality, and quantity of work. Gibson et al. provide evidence of adequate psychometric properties of the instrument. The items are cast on a 5-point Likert scale. The scale was created by averaging the responses to the items and a higher score indicated greater job performance. The instrument was completed by students’ respective supervisors at the end of the semester (Time 3).

Analysis and Results

The first part of the analysis was designed to test the psychometric properties of the EI, SH, and JP measures. Next analysis was designed

to test the four hypotheses of the study. The statistical package, LISREL 9.2 Jöreskog & Sörbom (1996a, 1996b) was used for data analysis.

Measurement Model. Confirmatory factor analysis of the EI, SH, and JP items were computed. First, the observed variables were allowed to load on a single factor. Second, the six-factor solution was computed, i.e. the observed variables were allowed to load on their specified factors. Table 1 shows that the six-factor solution has a better fit than the single-factor solution (see Table 1 in Appendix).

Convergent Validity. For this validity, the average variance extracted by all the items loading on a given factor should exceed .50. These values were averaged for factors and all of the average R^2 s exceeded .50. This value is the threshold for supporting convergent validity (see Table 2).

Convergent validity of the six subscales of the three measures was also assessed by examining whether each item had a statistically significant factor loading on its specified factor. Factor loadings were significant, with minimum z -values of 4.15 ($p < .001$). Evidence of the convergent validity of the three instruments was provided by these results.

Discriminant Validity. Evidence of this validity requires that the squared correlations between factors should be less than the average variance extracted for each factor (Carr, 2002). Results provide strong support for the discriminant validity of the measures.

Univariate Normality. For all the factors, skewness and kurtosis statistics were within the acceptable levels of 1 and 7. Therefore, the samples exhibited a high degree of univariate normality for the six factors. Table 2 shows the descriptive statistics and internal consistency and indicator reliabilities (see Appendix). Overall, these coefficients are satisfactory.

Each observed variable has a reported R^2 that measures the variable's variance explained by its factor. The R^2 s for all the variables ranged between .51 and .75, which provide evidence of indicator reliability. The internal consistency reliability, as measured by Cronbach α , for the five latent variables, ranged between .70 and .83. These reliability coefficients were judged adequate. Multicollinearity was not a problem as the variance inflation factors (VIFs) (ranged between 1.61–2.91) were lower than 10.00.

Structural Equations Model. To test the four study hypotheses a LISREL model was computed. Table 3 (see Appendix) shows that fit indexes for the full structural equations model were satisfactory. The relationships in Figure 1, represented by the solid lines, but not the broken lines, were all significant. Results in provided full support for the four study hypotheses.

Discussion

The study explores the relationship among emotional intelligence, subjective happiness, and job performance by looking specifically at how emotional intelligence, through its various components, could be causally associated with subjective happiness, which in turn, is associated with job performance. And, thus the study takes current literature one step forward, by not only exploring correlations, but causation among the three constructs. Therefore, the study makes a contribution to the literature on intelligence, subjective happiness, and job performance.

The results provide full support for the theoretical model presented in Figure 1. Previous studies did not test the relationships of respondents' perception of emotional intelligence, subjective happiness, and their respective supervisors' rating of job performance in a process model with LISREL. The study contributed to our understanding of the linkage between awareness of self and others and regulation of emotions in self and others, between regulation of emotions in self and others and using emotions for productive purposes, and between using emotions for productive purposes and subjective happiness and job performance.

The study provided acceptable evidence of convergent, discriminant, and criterion validities and Cronbach α internal consistency and indicator reliabilities of the measure of emotional intelligence and job performance. Finally, evidence from the present study provided some support for construct validity of the measure of emotional intelligence, subjective happiness, and job performance.

Implications for Management.

Employees in an organization need to acquire the four components of emotional intelligence to improve their subjective happiness and job performance and probably other desirable

outcomes. Interventions may be needed to enhance their emotional intelligence abilities that would involve education and specific job-related training. Competence that comprises emotional intelligence can be taught and developed (Brackett, Rivers, & Salovey, 2010). Employees should also be encouraged to enhance their abilities through continuous self-learning. Organizations can provide positive reinforcements for learning and improving employees' emotional intelligence competencies needed for various jobs.

Organization designs that involve creating flatter, decentralized, and less complex structures probably promote emotional intelligence. Also there should be appropriate changes in organizational culture that provides rewards for learning new competencies and for continuous questioning and inquiry. These changes in the organization design, culture, and positive reinforcements should encourage organizational members to acquire emotional intelligence competencies needed for improving their subjective happiness, job performance, satisfaction, and other important outcomes. In order to make these changes, organizations would require effective leaders who can facilitate these changes.

Although employees can be encouraged to improve their own emotional intelligence, this may not be sufficient to fully enhance their four components emotional intelligence. Organizations may have to adapt the policy of recruiting employees, particularly managers, who are likely to possess the four components of emotional intelligence. This suggests that organizations may be required to change their traditional criteria for selecting employees.

Strengths and Limitations

One of the major strengths of this study is that the data on the exogenous and endogenous were collected from two different respondents at three different times. Therefore, the results were not influenced by common method variance, which takes place when data are collected at the same time, from the same subjects, and with same measures. Also the six-factor confirmatory factor analysis provided better fit indexes than the single-factor analysis of the observed variables. The limitation of this field study should be noted. It is possible that data that were collected from a collegiate sample might limit generalizability of the results.

Directions for Future Research

Further research is needed to enhance our understanding of the relationships of the ability-based measures of emotional intelligence, subjective happiness, and the effectiveness of employee behaviors. Other criterion variables for future research should include some indicators of emotional intelligence of employees' and their satisfaction with work, turnover intention, motivation, and organizational citizenship behavior. An important area of future research concerns carefully designing and evaluating the effects of training in emotional intelligence in enhancing the aforementioned criterion variables. Field experiments are particularly useful in evaluating the effects of emotional intelligence training on individual and organizational outcomes. There is also need for scenario-based and laboratory studies that control some of the extraneous variables to better understand the relationships of employee emotional intelligence to criterion variables.

Future studies should also investigate the relationships among the three constructs for various organizational levels. Does an upper level manager require a greater sense of self-awareness? Managers at every level bring certain factors to the table, such as experience in decision making, and therefore will increase their level of confidence and intelligence as they go about making these decisions.

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Biographical Note

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Table 1
LISREL Summary Statistics

Statistic	Measurement Model		Structural Equations Model
	1-Factors	6-Factors	
χ^2/df	8.25	1.27	1.29
RMSEA	.18	.03	.03
Standardized RMR	.13	.03	.03
Normed Fit Index	.63	.96	.96
Comparative Fit Index	.52	.99	.99
Incremental Fit Index	.66	.99	.99
Relative Fit Index	.66	.93	.93
Goodness-of-Fit Index	.55	.97	.97

Note: RMSEA = Root mean square error of approximation, RMR = Root mean square residual. $\chi^2 (39) = 49.71$ for the model was nonsignificant, $p > .11$

Table 2
Means, Standard Deviations, Cronbach α and Indicator Reliabilities, Pearson Correlations, and Variance Inflation Factor

Variable	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	α	IR	1	2	3	4	5	VIF
1. Self-awareness	3.88	.65	.61	.57						1.97
2. Awareness of others	3.83	.67	.68	.60	.63					2.04
3. Regulation	3.63	.64	.59	.59	.53	.52				1.66
4. Using emotions	3.92	.69	.64	.63	.58	.61	.56			1.94
5. Subjective happiness	5.03	1.12	.75	.66	.28	.29	.27	.30		1.14
6. Job performance	3.04	1.10	.91	.75	.19	.15	.12	.10	.58	

Note: $N = 224$. Subjective happiness was measured with a 7-point Likert scale, but the rest of the variables were measured with a 5-point Likert scale. IR = Indicator reliability, VIF = Variance inflation factor. Correlations $\geq .10$ are significant at $p < .01$ (two-tailed). Awareness of others = Awareness of others' emotions, Regulation = Regulation of emotions of self and others, Using emotions = Using emotions for productive purposes

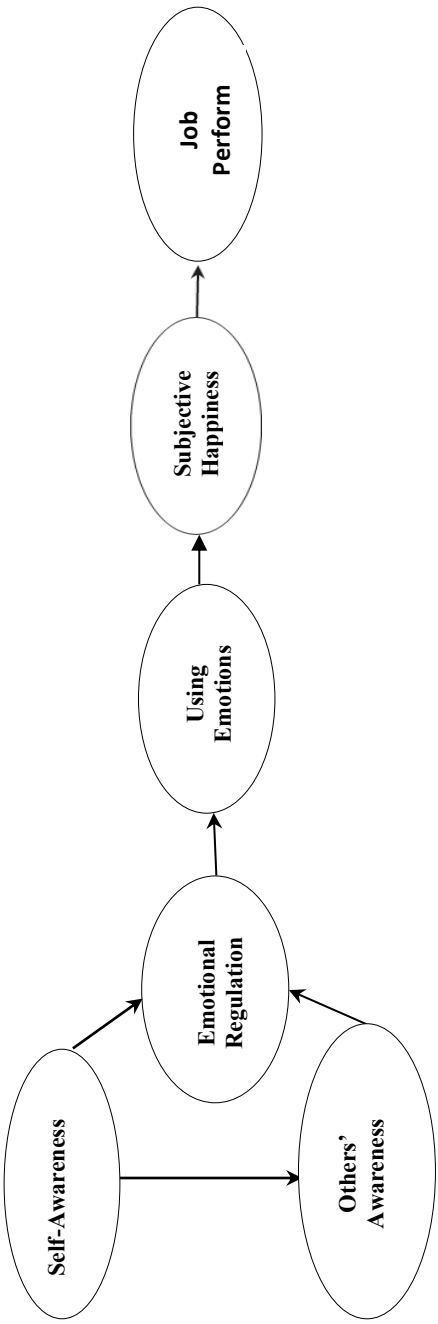
Table 3
Parameter Estimates for Structural Equations

Parameter path	Statistic	z-value
Self-awareness → Others' emotions	.81	9.43***
Self-awareness → Regulation of emotions	.41	2.93***
Awareness of others → Regulation of emotions	.78	9.12***
Regulation of emotions → Using emotions	.89	13.13***
Using emotions → Subjective happiness	.31	3.94***
Subjective happiness → Job performance	.25	3.02***

Note: The values are based on the causal model run on the covariance matrix. Regulation of Emotions = Regulation of emotions in self and others, Awareness of others' = Awareness of others' emotions, Using emotions = Using emotions for productive purposes

*** $p < .005$.

Figure 1
A Process Model of Emotional Intelligence, Subjective Happiness,
and Job Performance



Note: Others' awareness = Awareness of others' emotions, Emotional regulation = Regulation of emotions in self and others, Using emotions = Using emotions for productive purposes, Job perform = Job performance

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